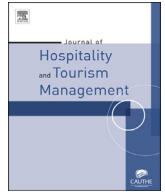




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Sensationalist media reporting of disastrous events: Implications for tourism



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ABSTRACT

Repeatedly in the tourism literature, reference is made to the negative implications of sensationalist media reporting of disasters on destination image. This assumption is yet to be empirically examined and there is a distinct lack of information in terms of the reporting approach used by national and global media, and their portrayal of disastrous events and the tourism destinations in which they take place. The primary objective of this paper is to examine how destinations affected by disastrous events are portrayed by the media in their coverage of the event. The content of 260 print and online media articles that reported the Blue Mountains Bushfires, a small scale disaster that occurred in 2011, is examined. Findings suggest that the media's representation or misrepresentation of this particular disaster may contribute to the estimated loss of over \$100 million in tourism related revenue experienced by this destination. Implications for the tourism industry regarding affective media management are presented.

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1. Introduction

Tourism is an industry known to be vulnerable to disasters and crises ranging from economic downturns, natural disasters, epidemic disasters and international conflicts (Faulkner, 2001; Sonmez, Apostolopoulos, & Tarlow, 1999). This vulnerability can cause losses in revenue and employment within tourism destinations and is evident in past disasters and crises. Examples include the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami, which resulted in a drop of 67.2 percent in tourism arrivals just in Phuket, Thailand, and a loss of employment for 3000 tourism workers (Henderson, 2007); the 2004 Avian Flu epidemic, which affected many Asia Pacific regions and resulted in a loss of 12 million tourists throughout the entire Asia Pacific (Wilder-Smith, 2006); and the 2011 Queensland Floods, which affected over 200,000 people in 70 towns and cities (Johnson et al., 2013) and caused estimated losses for the tourism industry of \$590 million (IBISWorld, 2011). On top of these negative impacts, disaster-stricken tourism destinations may need to commit resources and time for recovery and rebuilding.

In response to such events, disaster management plans and frameworks have been constructed and continuously improved to deal with inevitable disasters and crises (Johnson et al., 2013;

Ritchie, 2004). However, given that most disasters and crises cannot be fully prevented due to their unpredictable nature (Faulkner, 2001), the challenge is to continuously develop and improve existing response strategies (Kuppuswamy, 2013). A key component of these strategies relates to the management of destination image and visitors' perceptions of the destination (Lehto, Douglas, & Park, 2008). In the context of disasters, destinations are not only faced with the daunting tasks of rebuilding infrastructure, facilities and communities, but also image recovery (Armstrong & Ritchie, 2008; Lehto et al., 2008; Mair, Ritchie, & Walters, 2014; Ryu, Bordelon, & Pearlman, 2013) where the focus is on providing correct and consistent information to the public and enhancing the image of the destination faced with a crisis (Ritchie, 2004). The media is of course an important stakeholder in terms of communicating information concerning a crisis or disaster to various publics (including tourists) and also plays a key role in restoring confidence in an organization or destination during and after a disaster (Ritchie, 2004). However, it can be argued that the way the media reports on a crisis or disaster may influence image and perceptions differently.

Despite a lack of empirical testing, media reporting of disastrous events that is sensationalist is repeatedly assumed to be one of the primary influences of negative destination image in the wake of disastrous events (see for example; Armstrong & Ritchie, 2008; Beirman, 2006; Lehto et al., 2008; Pearlman & Melnik, 2008; Rittichainuwat, 2008). In a general sense, media reporting is

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known to influence risk perception (Wahlberg & Sjöberg, 2000) which is a common determinant in destination choice (Lepp & Gibson, 2003; Roehl & Fesenmaier, 1992; Sharifpour, Walters and Ritchie, 2014). However, other than briefly acknowledging the extent and range of media reports, research is yet to examine precisely how the media reports on disasters. Hystad and Keller (2008) and Prideaux (2004) have called for the development of a greater understanding of how the media functions in relation to disasters. Despite ongoing claims in the tourism literature regarding the negative impact that media reporting has on consumer perceptions of destinations following a disastrous event, this research is the first to analyse the nature of the media coverage in this context. Given that mainstream media is one of the most frequently consulted information sources by tourists in times of disaster (Walters, Mair, & Ritchie, 2015), it is necessary to further explore the way in which such events are portrayed to the public to gain an understanding of the likely impact of this information on the market place. This requires a two stage research process – initially to understand how the media reports on disastrous events, and secondly to understand the impact that this has on the tourism market. This paper reports on research into the first stage of the research process, and thus the aim of this research is to provide an in-depth analysis of the way in which the media reports disastrous events and their portrayal of affected destinations. In doing so, this research will provide detailed insight into the possible implications of such reporting for tourism managers responsible for the destination's image recovery.

2. Literature review

2.1. Destination image and the media

Tourist destination image can be defined as 'the sum of all those emotional and aesthetic qualities such as experiences, beliefs, ideas, recollections and impressions, that a person has of a destination' (Crompton, 1979). Destination image has been demonstrated to affect or influence the travel decision process (Baloglu & McCleary, 1999; Echtner & Ritchie, 1993; Gartner, 1993; Jenkins, 1999; Lehto et al., 2008). Gartner (1993) suggests that destination images consist of three components: Cognitive, Affective and Conative. The cognitive component is characterized by an evaluation of the known attributes of a destination based on the sum of beliefs and attitudes of a destination that is influenced by external stimuli. The affective component refers to the motives an individual has for a destination. This may refer to a potential tourist's evaluation of the destination's attributes based on the experience a tourist is seeking or is motivated to travel to the destination for. The conative component refers to the behavioural or action component of travel and decision-making. Walters et al. (2015) describe these components relative to disasters in the following terms: the cognitive image may be affected by information and updates (locations affected, damage, scale and scope of disasters) from the media and Internet sources; the affective (or emotional) image relates to the emotions felt by individuals such as sadness, shock and disbelief or alternatively, indifference; and the conative image or behavioural dimension, which may manifest itself in terms of cancellation of planned trips, shortening of stays and deferred decisions related to travelling to destinations.

Gartner (1993) also suggests that there are forces that influence the forming of perceptions and evaluations of images and divides them into 'image forming agents'. The media are considered to be 'autonomous change agents' (Beerli & Martín, 2004; Gartner, 1993). Such autonomous image formation agents have high levels of credibility and market penetration among the public, yet are not under the direct control of the destination. Gartner and Jingqing

(1992) have also indicated in their research that "autonomous" image formation agents have a more immediate effect than other image formation agents. Further, Beirman's (2003) study proposes that while the mass media looks to generate awareness, it also holds significant power in relation not only to shaping viewers' perceptions of a disaster itself but also the destination where a disaster takes place. Beerli and Martín (2004) add that these agents are difficult to control although they also stress the importance for destinations of collaborating more directly with the media in an attempt to manage and keep track of the images broadcasted.

Autonomous agents such as the news media have the power to alter images quickly, particularly where large audiences worldwide watch repetitive scenes of an event (Tasci et al., 2007). In their research, the disaster of Hurricane Katrina demonstrates this well – in a matter of 24 h, the world saw the city of New Orleans transform from an iconic place revered for music, food, and festival to a deluge of despair, flooding, death, crime, violence, and destruction (Tasci et al., 2007). In addition, media representation can vary, sometimes portraying the disaster inaccurately (Burnett, 1998). As Walters and Mair (2012) demonstrated, the media reports of Black Saturday bushfires portrayed the fires to be more widely spread across the state of Victoria than they actually were. This particular case demonstrates that the media could be responsible for confusing people about the actual extent of the damage at the geographical location of the disaster.

It is acknowledged that there is a plethora of reasons for variation in tourist behaviour, and that media is only one aspect of this. Tourists may change or cancel plans for reasons other than media coverage (for example because of damage to the tangible tourist product such as hotels or attractions, or because of uncertainty about the quality of the post-disaster experience). However, the media clearly has a significant impact on the way that a disaster and the risks involved are defined and presented to the public (Vasterman, Yzermans, & Dirkzwager, 2005). Therefore it is pertinent to review the media literature on communication in times of disasters in order to understand exactly how media reporting achieves this.

2.2. Media and communication in times of crisis and disaster

When it comes to reporting a news story, the media plays both an 'agenda setting' and a 'framing' role (Vasterman et al., 2005). Agenda-setting theory, originally proposed as a way of explaining how media coverage shaped the political views and voting intentions of the American public (McCombs & Shaw, 1972), explains how the salience of certain issues changes with the differential media emphasis and coverage. This theory had its foundations in the now often quoted line "The press may not be successful much of the time in telling people what to think, but it is stunningly successful in telling its readers what to think about" (Cohen, 1963, p. 13). Agenda setting theory suggests that in choosing and displaying news, those in the media (editors, journalists and broadcasters amongst others) play an important part in shaping public opinion. The media often covers topics or events with a view to influencing public opinion and public policy so as to urge policymakers to take the necessary actions to fulfil the public interest (Birkland, 1997). Since its origins in the 1970's, agenda setting theory has been divided into two key areas – first level and second level agenda setting (McCombs, Llamas, Lopez-Excobar, & Rey, 1998). First level agenda setting refers to the salience of a given issue – how important a topic is to the public. However, second level agenda setting refers more to what we (the public) should think about an issue (McCombs et al., 1998). This is key to understanding how the media can influence public opinion in favour of, or against a given topic, idea or argument. In the disaster context, the media have

been accused of focusing on bad news, rather than highlighting the positives (Voorhees, Vick, & Perkins, 2007). For example, according to Moeller (2006), the media underreported disaster management during Hurricane Katrina and instead focused on issues such as racial profiling, violence and exaggerating lawlessness.

Another media theory of relevance to this study is framing. Frames are basically the lens through which an individual 'sees' the media coverage (Nisbet & Mooney, 2007) and framing is the processes of "selecting and highlighting some facets of events or issues, and making connections among them so as to promote a particular interpretation, evaluation and/or solution" (Entman, 2004, p.5). Frames allow an individual to cut through complex issues and identify why an issue matters, who might be responsible and what should be done (Nisbet & Mooney, 2007). The media plays a key role in frame building and setting (communicating the frame through the interaction between media frames and individuals' prior knowledge) (De Vreese, 2005; McLennan, Becken, & Moyle, 2014). Birkland (1997) highlights the role of individual journalists, who in framing a story, create a central theme and emphasise specifically selected elements of the event. The frames that are built are a result of the interaction between journalists, public and stakeholders (Birkland, 1997; Kuttischreuter, Gutteling, & de Hond, 2011; Scheufele, 1999). Framing also involves developing an understanding or gaining new insights on a particular issue (Chong & Druckman, 2007).

Framing is similar to second level agenda setting (McCombs et al., 1998). Those reading or watching the news not only learn about a given issue, but, in line with the amount and type of media coverage, decide how much importance to attach to that issue (McCombs & Shaw, 1972). News can be constructed using a balanced frame, by which the event or, in this case, disaster related information is put into a useful context and important facts are relayed to the public using a relatively moderate tone. Alternatively, news is presented using a dramatized and sensationalised one sided frame where the event is used as a means of enhancing readership and increasing ratings. Prior research has noted that the media commonly frames different types of stories during a disaster to contextualise and communicate its message – disaster education (current, ongoing and immediate), severity, racial disparity, human interest, economic consequences, terms of conflict, attitudinal framing, and ethical and moral considerations (Campbell, 2014; Dutta, 2013; Kuttischreuter et al., 2011; Liu, 2009; Tierney, Bevc, & Kuligowski, 2006; Voorhees et al., 2007). More specifically, however, it has been suggested that sensational frames have a detrimental effect on a destination image. The media presents this by distorting reports of disaster events, often via multiple media channels (Dutta, 2013; Kuppuswamy, 2013).

Media sensationalism, often seen during disastrous events, is a type of editorial bias in mass media in which such events are over-hyped to increase readership numbers. Paracha, Shahzad, Ali, and Nazir (2013) define sensationalism as subjective news that brings thrill and panic in the community. This may include reporting biased presentations of newsworthy topics in a trivial or tabloid manner contrary to the standards of professional journalism and often includes the use of sensationalist language such as metaphors, hyperboles and emotive expressions to attract reader attention (Davis & McLeod, 2003; Tierney et al., 2006). Past research has revealed that sensationalist media reporting of crises can produce a range of negative impacts on society such as post-traumatic stress disorder (Ahern, Galea, Resnick & Vlavhov, 2002); poor health and mass psychogenic illness (Wessely, 1987) and even suicide (Stack, 2003). Sensationalism is closely related to media hypes where the media coverage is perceived to be out of proportion to the event being covered. Media hypes are triggered by unusual or shocking events which are framed in such a way that

the media constantly 'hunt' for 'newer' news on the topic (Kepplinger & Habermeyer, 1995). The self-referential system creates a positive feedback loop which consequently expands the news wave. During media hype, the media will generate more news on the topic by reporting comparable events, reinterpreting events in the past and paying attention to society's actions (Vasterman et al., 2005). A specific frame guides newsgathering and news making efforts and generally results in imbalanced reporting and risk amplification (Dunwoody, 1992). Anecdotally, exaggeration and sensationalised reporting is very common, and the exaggeration of the magnitude of events creates long-term damage for tourism destinations (Marra, 1998; Volo, 2008; Young & Montgomery, 1997). In addition, the visual images that accompany such reports are designed to shock and captivate audiences (Ryu et al., 2013). Slaterry, Doremus, and Marcus (2001) further add that sensationalised news content leads to misperceptions about the true nature of a scenario and increases the likelihood to foster unrealistic decisions and choices. In a disaster context, the media's attempt to increase readership via the use of shocking headlines as opposed to accurate and balanced descriptions of the event may in turn result in misperceptions of the extent of the disaster and its impact on the affected destination. Destination managers are therefore left with the responsibility of restoring the image of the destination in response to this sensationalised news coverage.

Agenda setting, framing and sensationalism provide a theoretical foundation to better understand media coverage of disastrous events. These three inter-related concepts have been employed by the researchers to guide their analysis of the media coverage of the Blue Mountains Bushfires that occurred in late 2013. This research aims to analyse the media coverage of a disastrous event in a bid to identify the way that affected destinations are portrayed to the general public and potential tourists. The context for this study was the 2013 Blue Mountains Bushfires.

3. Methodology

The Blue Mountains is a mountainous area in New South Wales, Australia. It starts around 50 km inland from Sydney, and is notable for several tourist towns and attractions including Katoomba and Mount Victoria, and a scenic railway. The Greater Blue Mountains Area was listed as a World Heritage Area by UNESCO in the year 2000. On 17th October 2013, bushfires in the area burned out of control, causing one fatality. The fires threatened the Blue Mountains community for a period of 10 days. Over two hundred homes were lost and 160,000 ha of land were burnt. Despite the comparatively small scale of this disaster when compared to other Australian disasters such as the 2009 Black Saturday Bushfires and the 2011 Queensland Floods, it is estimated that the loss of tourism related income following the event was around AUD\$100 million (Blue Mountains Economic Enterprise, 2014).

3.1. Research approach

This study employs a quasi-qualitative approach, a hybrid methodology in the form of a content analysis, where quantitative elements are utilised to assist in categorising certain words and codes together in a qualitative data analysis (Knodel & Saengtienchai, 1999). Neuendorf (2002) defines content analysis as "the systematic, objective, quantitative analysis of message characteristics" (p.1). Harwood and Garry (2003) describe this concept as one that is usually qualitative in the development stages of research and quantitative where it is applied to determine frequency of phenomena of interest. While the message characteristics are initially coded, characterised and compared using qualitative techniques in order to develop themes (Harwood &

Garry, 2003), a quantitative approach is then employed to determine the frequency and prominence of these themes (Stemler, 2001). Content analysis is commonly employed for media analyses (Harwood & Garry, 2003; Riffe, Lacy, & Fico, 2014) and previous examples of its use in tourism research include McLennan, Becken, and Moyle's (2014) study of the media representation of tourism and mining and Ruhanen, McLennan & Moyle's (2013) analysis of Australian national-level tourism strategic planning documents.

3.2. Sample

This research analysed the manifest content of the headlines used by a range of print media articles available online between October 17 and December 25 2013 which reported on the Blue Mountains Bushfires. Headlines were specifically chosen as they can be considered as 'relevance optimisers', i.e. they assist the reader to decide whether the article is relevant to them, and therefore worth reading or not (Dor, 2003). Indeed, research suggests that most readers spend more of their reading time scanning the headlines than reading the stories (Dor, 2003). Traditionally, newspaper headlines served as short summaries of the news contained within an article. However, this is not always the case, as Bell (1991) points out, noting that the function of headlines is to attract the reader. While it is acknowledged that media can be in the form of broadcast, print and online, and that social media is becoming an increasingly popular news source, print media, i.e. newspaper articles available in hard copy or online were used as the focus of this study due to the ease of access for both the audience and the researchers. Search terms entered into Google News (<https://news.google.com.au>) included (but were not limited to) 'Blue Mountains', 'NSW', 'Sydney', 'Australia/n', 'bushfires', 'disaster', 'emergency', 'evacuation' and 'fire warnings'. The search generated a number of replicated articles and these were eliminated from the selection. The final count of relevant articles was 260. Microsoft Access was used to manage and sort the data. As this was exploratory quasi-qualitative research, the categorisation of material was done on a discretionary and judgmental basis, as is often the case with content analysis, and therefore the results of this study are not intended to be generalisable to other contexts or media (Eriksson & Kovalainen, 2008).

Once the researchers agreed on the final selection of articles, the headlines were categorised in the first instance based on the time of publication. To explore the extent of local (within NSW), national and international exposure the Blue Mountains fires incurred, and to examine the geographical terms of reference used by the media, noted by Walters and Mair (2012) as problematic and potentially confusing for readers, counts based on the media audience and the geographic references made were reviewed in alignment with the time frames (see Table 1).

4. Results

The data in the table above suggests that the terms of reference used to report the location of the fire itself differed according to the intended media audience. Internationally, the media referred to the fires in their headlines as the Australian bushfires with very little reference made to their exact locality. Interstate, or when reaching out to the national audiences, the state of New South Wales was used as the most common geographical reference point, although the Blue Mountains was directly referred to in over a third of these media articles. When reporting to audiences within New South Wales, the majority of the headlines referred to the Blue Mountains region. The New South Wales media also reported on the fires for the longest period of time with the last disaster relevant headline

being printed over two months following the event. While this may appear intuitive and is easily explained by the need for different media outlets to shape stories in a way that makes sense to their specific audience, the connection between a lack of precision regarding the location of a disaster, and the potential for this geographical confusion to damage destination image is currently under-researched.

4.1. Agenda setting and the Blue Mountains Bush Fires

As discussed above, agenda setting refers to the media's ability to draw public attention to the importance of an event and in doing so shape or influence public opinion. The fact that over the week of the Blue Mountains fires the print media published 187 articles indicates that this event was definitely something the media wanted on the public agenda first and foremost. With regards to second level agenda setting it was clear that the media wanted to induce negative emotions towards the disaster with 89 percent of these headlines reporting the fires in a negative manner. The literature identifies similarities between agenda setting and media framing in terms of audience persuasion and hence an analysis of the way in which the media 'framed' the bushfire event in their headlines also provides some insight into the agenda set by the media.

4.2. Media framing and the Blue Mountains Bush Fires

In order to understand how the media were framing the bushfires, an analysis of the headlines was undertaken. This analysis revealed that overall the reporting was highly imbalanced, with the majority of headlines over the initial two week period being negative. Further, the headlines analysed in this study presented a range of themes and issues, but many were indicative of the media's dramatization of the event. These are presented in the following table (see Table 2).

The first frame, 'unprecedented disaster', relates to the attention given by the media to the scale of the disaster. This frame aimed to draw the reader's attention to the severity of the event by emphasising the amount of time that had passed since a similar event occurred. Compared with other Australian bushfire disasters such as the 2009 Black Saturday Bushfires, this bushfire covered a significantly smaller area. However, the headlines seemed to suggest that this fire was unprecedented in its severity.

Chaos or loss of control was the second frame identified in the headlines with words such 'unknown', 'debacle' and 'out of control' suggesting to the public that authorities were not able to contain the fires themselves or affectively manage the necessary activities associated with them.

The loss and grief felt by the Blue Mountains community was a frame used in a significant number of headlines with an emphasis being placed on the impact that the fires had on the local community and in particular families. A frame that appeared in the weeks following the event was that of altruism and community support. These headlines (18 in total) focused on the generosity of other states and local and federal government monetary support for the region and its people as well as efforts by volunteer organisations and the community itself. This represented the only example of 'positive' framing across the 260 headlines. This is clear evidence of the unbalanced nature of the reporting of the bushfire.

The final frame identified was the longer term demise of the destination. Reference to the cost of the disaster to tourism in the Blue Mountains was made as well as the economic losses experienced by local businesses. The bushfire, and its 'potential' impact on the destination, was mentioned in over twenty headlines. For members of the public not fully aware of the actual situation, these

Table 1
Media audience and geographic references used to report the 2013 Blue Mountains Bushfires.

DATE-2013	N	Media audience	Geographical reference made by media	%
17th Oct–23rd Nov	62	International	Australia	46%
			New South Wales	23%
			South Eastern Australia	13%
			Blue Mountains	10%
			Sydney	8%
17th Oct–17th Dec	122	National	New South Wales	41%
			Blue Mountains	35%
			Actual Township (Lithgow)	9%
			Sydney	8%
			Other	8%
17th Oct–25th Dec	76	New South Wales	Blue Mountains	65%
			New South Wales	21%
			Townships	11%
			Sydney	3%

Table 2
The Media's framing of the Blue Mountains Bush Fires.

Frame	Valence of headline	No. of articles	Exemplar headlines
1 Unprecedented disaster	Negative	15	- NSW bushfires threat 'unparalleled' as conditions worsen - The most dangerous bushfire the Blue Mountains has faced since 1994 - In the grip of the worst bushfire to ever hit the Blue Mountains - As bad as it gets; Australia braces for worst of wildfires
2 Chaos – lack of control of the situation	Negative	49	- Sydney bushfires: out of control blaze is worst in a decade - Family flees fires in fear of unknown - NSW bushfire clean-up a debacle: mayor - Thousands facing bushfire calamity in NSW - NSW: 'Massive problem' with fire clean-up: mayor - Sydney under threat as fires continue to burn - Flames outrun telephone warnings NOTIFICATION -BUSHFIRE CRISIS - Australia bushfires rage out of control - Residents angry at evacuation confusion
3 Loss and grief	Negative	39	- Blue Mountains families arrive at evacuation centre armed with treasured items - Families in shock as fire destroys all - Tourism losses hit \$30 m after Blue Mountains bushfires - Springwood and Winmalee residents search for normality amid bushfire disaster - Bushfire aftermath: the devastation a 'tornado of fire' wreaks on a community
4 Altruism – Community Support	Positive	18	- Guardian Angels - Volunteers begin hunt for burned animals - Father-and-son team a model of enduring mateship VOLUNTEERS – BUSHFIRE CRISIS - From the ashes, a food-led revival - The Blue Mountains Bushfire Mayoral Relief Fund has \$3 million - More help for NSW bushfire victims
5 Demise of the Destination	Negative	24	- WA: WA donate \$250,000 to bushfire appeal - Blaze causes millions of damage to Lithgow's iconic Zig Zag Railway - Worst case scenario: Blue Mountains blazes threaten to combine into mega fire - Blue Mountains fires to keep firefighters busy for weeks - Tourism hurting after Blue Mountains Bushfires - National parks staff in the bushfire-ravaged NSW Blue Mountains - Three huge bushfires in the Blue Mountains

headlines could have suggested that the damage to the destination was far greater than it actually was.

4.3. Sensationalist media reporting and the Blue Mountains Bushfires

To determine the extent to which the media sensationalised the Blue Mountains Bush Fire event, the researchers identified headlines that used metaphors, hyperboles and emotional connotations to attract reader attention. Table 3 below presents examples of the kinds of sensationalist language that were used in the media headlines that reported on the event.

The data presented in the table above indicates that the media employed a combination of sensationalist and dramatic terms and phrases in their headlines to draw their audience's attention to the Blue Mountains fires. Metaphorical terms such as '*as bad as it gets*',

'*catastrophic*' and '*mega fire*' suggest that the fire was unprecedented, out of control and exceptionally large, while hyperboles used to describe the situation such as '*Armageddon*??' and '*three days in hell*' liken the disaster to a horror event that may perhaps instil a sense of fear among readers. Finally, attempts were made by the media to generate emotive interest among the various targeted audiences via headlines that gave reference to the impact the bushfire was having on families, community members and women and children.

Interestingly and perhaps in an attempt to continue to use the disaster to maintain sales, the media appeared to attempt to extend the life of the news story. In the weeks following the actual fires, attempts were made by the media to revitalise the threat of bushfire activity by suggesting that more fire activity was expected, despite this not being the case. This also appears indicative of attempts to sensationalise a bushfire event that was rapidly

Table 3
Examples of sensationalist language used to report the Blue Mountains Bushfires.

Metaphors	Hyperboles	Emotive phrasing
Armageddon	Nightmare	Firestorm destroys communities
D-Day	Three days in hell	Thousands flee their home
Wall of fire	As bad as it gets	Families unimaginable grief seared into the landscape
The fires raged...	Inferno	Family flees fires in fear of unknown
The fires ravaged...	Mega fire/super fire	Mother forced from home for second time
Hellfire	Catastrophic	Families in shock as fire destroys all
		Troubled Children need post-bushfire help
		Heartbreak

disappearing from the headlines.

5. Discussion

While it needs to be recognised that the media plays an integral role in the communication and dissemination of information relating to the onset, duration and aftermath of a disastrous event, we argue that based on the results of this study, media coverage of such events can be somewhat imbalanced, that is skewed towards negative vs positive news stories, and highly sensationalised. This, accompanied by inaccurate geographical references as to the precise location of the fires, may have caused significant reputational damage not only to the affected destination but also neighbouring capital cities and even among global audiences, potentially the entire nation.

Disaster stories have high audience interest and tend to diffuse very rapidly (Sood, 1983). News media see disasters as an opportunity to provide valuable and much needed updates to affected communities and increase their broadcast ratings (Emery, Roberts, & Emery, 2000). From a tourism perspective however, it is apparent that the media gives little consideration to the consequences for the affected destination that, as a result of their coverage, may experience significant economic losses. It is estimated that as a result of the Blue Mountains bushfires, the local tourism industry incurred a loss of close to \$100 million in tourism related income (Blue Mountains Economic Enterprise, 2014). While this study does not provide empirical evidence that this loss was in part due to the media's representation of the disaster, the following discussion will draw on the results of this study to present a case as to why the media's coverage of the Blue Mountains fires may have contributed to the temporary downturn in tourism.

First, confusion over geographical proximity plays a significant role in fuelling understanding of the extent of the disaster and the affected areas (Beirman, 2003). The Blue Mountains fire affected 160,000 ha of land and was restricted to a number of small townships at the base of the mountains. No key tourism attractions were damaged or threatened by the blaze, however the media's reference to the event as the 'Blue Mountains fires' would have possibly created the mindset that the entire region was damaged, destroyed or at the very least – closed for business. Broader reputational damage was also incurred as almost half of the headlines circulated in the international media referred to the fires as the Australian bushfires while in the national media the most common term of reference was the New South Wales bushfires. This may have caused significant confusion among these target audiences as to the precise location of the fires. In turn, this broadens the reputational damage to a national level as interstate and international tourists may eradicate both New South Wales and Australia from their destination choice set (Walters & Clulow, 2010).

We conclude from the analysis of the media's agenda that they were very concerned with a) making the Blue Mountains fires a 'top of mind' issue for their readers and b) generating negative

emotional responses. The profound use of negatively phrased emotive headlines to report the disaster over the entire reporting period would have had a significant impact on the perceptions of potential tourists, namely the actual location of the destination and the risks involved in visiting the region (Vasterman et al., 2005). These risks may include the psychological risk tourists associate with having a bad experience at the destination or the risks related to their physical safety and well-being (Sharifpour et al., 2014).

In terms of how the media framed the Blue Mountains fires, the analysis demonstrated support for previous research that suggests that typically disastrous events are framed in an imbalanced manner (Dutta, 2013; Kuppaswamy, 2013). Four of the five frames identified in the analysis dramatized the severity of the event by drawing attention to its unprecedented nature and the supposed lack of control authorities had over the fires. These headlines may have instilled a sense of fear and a lack of confidence among those considering visiting the Blue Mountains, whilst the headlines focusing on the demise of the destination may have raised some issues as to the actual status of tourist attractions and the image of the destination as a whole. The framing around the loss and grief experienced by the community and the associated 'tug at the heart strings' headlines may have also had an impact on the affective image of a destination held by potential visitors. According to Walters et al. (2015) this kind of attention creates concern among tourists as to the general ambience of the destination which again is unlikely to provide a positive and 'upbeat' tourist experience. According to Gorney (1992), seldom do the media counter their negative frames by providing sufficient facts in the copy of their articles that allow readers to create an informed opinion about a particular issue. In a tourism context, this responsibility lies with the destination managers who are consequently left with the task of mitigating the negative perceptions induced by the media's coverage in the aftermath of the event.

The use of metaphors, hyperboles and highly emotive phrasing in the media's disaster related headlines combined with the imbalanced framing discussed above provides some evidence that the Blue Mountains fires were highly sensationalised by the national and international media. With reference to Slattery et al. (2001), these sensationalised headlines may have led to misperceptions among the readers and/or potential tourists about the true nature of what was, comparatively speaking, a minor bushfire event. The current research cannot provide empirical support for a direct relationship between the way in which the fires were portrayed to the public and the steep decline in visitation experienced post disaster. However, given that tourist motivations are primarily based on the seeking of positive and rejuvenating experiences (Crompton, 1979), and Slattery et al.'s (2001) suggestion that sensationalist reporting may foster unnecessary cancellation decisions, it is not unreasonable to infer that those who have been exposed to this media coverage may have some difficulty believing that the Blue Mountains was able to provide a satisfying tourist experience.

6. Conclusions

This paper explored the media's representation of the 2013 Blue Mountains bushfire event in a bid to reveal how the destination was portrayed to the general public through print media headlines and has proposed some possible implications of this portrayal for the region's tourism industry. It was concluded that in their coverage of the event, the media used sensationalised headlines that were predominantly negative to generate interest among national and international audiences. It can be inferred that this negative publicity may contribute to the significant decline in visitor numbers experienced by the Blue Mountains. This represents a conflict between the goals and objectives of the media and those of destination managers seeking to protect the image of the affected destination and retain visitor numbers. To this end we make the following recommendations.

The tourism industry need to take a pro-active stance in building a better understanding of the consequences of negative sensationalist reporting for the media by emphasising the impact of such coverage on the local and national economy. While it is acknowledged that the media plays a vital role in the dissemination of important disaster-related information and noted that creative headlines are instrumental to the attraction of reader attention, the media need to be encouraged to offset their emotionally laden headlines with fact driven details. Further, destination managers need to encourage the media to refer to the precise locality of the fires and also mention those areas that remain unaffected. Ensuring that someone representing the tourism industry is always readily available for media comment is also important as, given the limited editorial timelines available to reporters, they will often seek comments from those who are not necessarily aware of the disaster-related facts. Inviting the media to return and report on positive news stories related to the recovery efforts of the destination is also a way in which the destination may counter the negative news frames communicated during and immediately following the event. Finally, to open the lines of communication between the media and the tourism industry in the event of a disaster, it is recommended that tourism managers include media stakeholders in their formal disaster preparation activities and have in place a mutually beneficial media strategy should a disaster occur.

This research marks one of the first attempts to further our understanding of the kinds of messages the media is sending to the public about tourism destinations when reporting on a disastrous event. It is important at this point to acknowledge the limitations of the scope of this research – that being the Blue Mountains bushfires and its inclusion of on-line media headlines only. In particular, it is worth noting that the focus of the study on print media excluded television and radio coverage and as such the important role of local television and radio (for example the Australian Broadcasting Corporation) was excluded from this study. Future research should include a variety of media. Further, and very importantly, this research did not attempt to confirm a direct relationship between the media reports and the decline in visitor numbers. As noted in the Introduction, demonstrating a link between sensationalist reporting and any impact this has on the tourism market is a two stage research process and this paper only deals with the initial stage – demonstrating that there is indeed sensationalist reporting by print media outlets. Future research is required to establish any relationship between sensationalist reporting and declining visitor numbers, an assumption that is often made in tourism research that focuses on crisis and disasters. Future research should also explore the interplay between mainstream and social media in terms of the role that public commentary can play in mitigating the negative perceptions caused by

sensationalist media reporting. Finally, it is accepted that there may be other variables at play which have an effect on tourist behaviour in a post-disaster period, such as actual damage to the tourism product, and therefore future research should take into account a wider range of possible influences on any behaviour changes.

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